PAW & FOUND



Pet Photo Tips

Take Great Photos with Just Your Phone

Lighting • Composition • Action shots • Simple editing

Capture your pet's personality — no fancy camera needed

📱 Why Your Phone Is All You Need

💡 The Best Camera = The One You Have

Modern smartphones have incredible cameras. The secret to great pet photos isn't expensive gear — it's understanding light, timing, and your pet. These tips work with any phone, from the latest iPhone to a budget Android.

☀️ Natural Light Is Everything

- **Window light is magic:** Position your pet near a window. The soft, diffused light is flattering and eliminates harsh shadows.
- **Golden hour:** The hour after sunrise and before sunset gives warm, beautiful light. Your pet's fur will glow.
- **Avoid direct overhead sun:** It creates harsh shadows and squinting. Find open shade on bright days.
- **Turn off the flash!** Flash creates red-eye, washes out fur color, and startles pets. Use natural light whenever possible.

🏠 Best Indoor Lighting Spots

Near a large window • On a light-colored rug/blanket • Under a skylight • In a room with white walls (bounces light) • NOT: directly under ceiling lights (unflattering shadows)

🎨 Composition: Framing the Perfect Shot

👁️ Get Down to Their Level

The #1 mistake pet owners make: shooting from above. Get on the floor, eye-to-eye with your pet. This creates intimate, engaging photos that show their world from their perspective.

📐 Rule of Thirds

Imagine a tic-tac-toe grid on your screen (most phones can display one in settings). Place your pet's eyes along the top horizontal line. Don't always center them — off-center creates more dynamic, interesting photos.

🖼️ Fill the Frame

Get close! Fill 70-80% of the frame with your pet. Crop out distracting backgrounds. Your phone's 2x or 3x zoom (optical, not digital) is great for this. Focus on details: eyes, nose, paws, expressive ears.

🧹 Clean Backgrounds Win

Before you shoot, scan the background: Is there laundry on the floor? A distracting outlet? A messy coffee table? Move the clutter or change angles. A clean background makes your pet the star.

📣 Getting Your Pet's Attention

🪀 The Sound Arsenal

- **Squeaky toy behind the phone:** Hold it right above your lens — your pet looks directly at the camera.
- **Weird noises:** Kissing sounds, tongue clicks, high-pitched "pup-pup-pup!", or a soft whistle. Anything unusual gets their ears up and eyes on you.
- **Crinkle a treat bag:** Instant attention. Reward them after a few shots so they stay motivated.
- **Say their favorite word:** "Walk?" "Treat?" "Park?" — but only if you mean it!

🍖 The Treat Trick

Hold a treat right next to your phone lens (touching it). Your pet will stare right at the camera. Snap the photo, then give the treat. Works every time for that perfect "looking at you" shot.

🐱 Cat-Specific Tips

- Crinkle paper or foil — cats can't resist investigating
- A wand toy waved near the camera gets their hunting stare
- Catnip applied 10 minutes before = playful expressions
- Dangle a string over the phone — they'll track it with their eyes

🏃 Action Shots: Freeze the Energy

💨 Burst Mode Is Your Best Friend

Hold down the shutter button (or volume up) to take 10-20 photos per second. You'll capture in-between moments you'd never get with a single shot — mid-air catches, goofy expressions, perfect paw placement. Pick the best one later.

🎯 Predicting the Moment

- **Fetch:** Start burst mode as they're about to catch the ball — the catch face is priceless.
- **Running:** Shoot from the side at their level. Pan slightly (follow them with your phone) for a sharp subject and blurred background.
- **Shaking off water:** Burst mode right after a bath or swim. The wild expressions are gold.
- **Zoomies:** Pre-focus on a spot they'll run through. Wait. Burst when they enter the frame.

⚡ Use the Right Settings

- Enable **burst mode** (hold shutter or volume up button)
- Use **portrait mode** for still subjects — it blurs the background beautifully
- **Live Photos** (iPhone) let you pick the best frame after the fact
- For very fast action, increase brightness slightly — it forces faster shutter speed

🎭 Pet Portrait Tips

🖼️ The Classic Portrait

- Find a simple background: a blank wall, a textured blanket, or outdoors with distant blur.
- Use **Portrait Mode** — it mimics the look of a professional camera with blurred backgrounds.
- Get eye-to-eye. Focus on the nearest eye — sharp eyes make or break a portrait.
- Leave "look room" — if your pet is facing left, place them on the right side of the frame.

🧸 Add Personality with Props

- A favorite toy in frame tells a story
- Seasonal props: autumn leaves, holiday lights, summer flowers
- A cozy blanket or their bed adds warmth
- Keep it minimal — one prop, not a scene from a catalog

⏰ Patience Wins

The best portraits come from short, fun sessions — not forced posing. Shoot for 5 minutes, then play. Come back later. A tired, happy pet photographs better than a frustrated one. If it stops being fun, stop.

🐱 Capturing Cat Personality

🪟 Window Light Magic

Cats are drawn to windows. Photograph them on a windowsill in natural light — the side-lighting highlights their fur texture and creates beautiful catchlights in their eyes. Morning light is especially flattering.

😴 Candid Moments

Cats are most photogenic when they're relaxed: sleeping in a sunbeam, stretching after a nap, slowly blinking at you, or grooming. Don't wake them — wait for these natural moments and shoot quietly.

🧶 Catnip Timing

Apply catnip 10-15 minutes before you want to shoot. Capture the playful, rolling, blissful expressions. But stop before overstimulation — a zooming cat is hard to photograph.

👀 The "I'm Watching You" Shot

Cats peeking around corners, from inside boxes, or under blankets create mystery and charm. These "hidden" shots capture their curious nature. Focus on the eyes peeking out.

🐶 Capturing Dog Spirit

🌳 Outdoor Action

Dogs come alive outdoors. Shoot at a park, beach, or trail. Morning and late afternoon light is best. Get low, use burst mode, and capture running, jumping, and playing.

😋 The Tongue-Out Smile

After exercise, dogs pant with big happy smiles. This is the perfect time for expressive, joyful portraits. The relaxed, open-mouth expression shows pure dog happiness.

💧 Water and Splash Shots

Dogs playing in water are pure joy. Use burst mode, protect your phone (waterproof case!), and shoot from a low angle. The splashing water, flying ears, and happy faces are magic.

🎾 The Head Tilt

Make a curious noise — a soft whistle, a weird word, a squeak. Dogs tilt their heads when they're trying to understand. It's the most endearing expression you'll ever capture. Reward heavily after!

✂️ Simple Editing (No Degree Required)

📱 Built-In Tools Are Enough

Your phone's Photos app already has everything you need. You don't need Photoshop or Lightroom. Focus on these three adjustments:

- **Crop:** Remove distractions, tighten the composition. Straighten horizons.
- **Brightness:** Bump up slightly if the photo is dark. Don't overdo it.
- **Warmth:** Add a touch of warmth (+5-10) for golden, cozy pet photos.

⚡ The 30-Second Edit

1. Crop to improve composition (2-3 seconds)
2. Increase brightness +5 to +15 (5 seconds)
3. Add warmth +5 to +10 (3 seconds)
4. Tap "Auto" and see if you like it (1 second)
5. Undo if it's worse (1 second)
6. Done! (rest of the 30 seconds)

🚫 What NOT to Do

- Don't over-filter — pets look best natural
- Don't oversaturate — neon grass looks fake
- Don't use heavy blur effects — they look dated
- Don't over-sharpen — it creates unnatural edges on fur

📤 Sharing & Printing

📱 Instagram Best Practices

- **Square (1:1):** 1080×1080px — classic and reliable
- **Portrait (4:5):** 1080×1350px — takes up more screen space, higher engagement
- **Use 2-3 relevant hashtags:** #PetPhotography #DogsofInstagram #Catstagram
- **Post at peak times:** Early morning and evening
- **Stories:** Behind-the-scenes, bloopers, daily moments

🖼️ Printing Your Photos

- **4×6 prints:** At least 1200×1800px
- **8×10 prints:** At least 2400×3000px
- **Photo books:** Mix action shots + portraits. Tell a story.
- **Canvas prints:** Choose your sharpest portrait. Clean background works best.
- **Phone cases, mugs, etc.:** Great gifts for pet lovers!

🎯 5 Quick Photo Challenges

Try one each day — you'll be amazed at how fast you improve!

📸 CHALLENGE 1: EYE-LEVEL

Get on the floor and take 10 photos from your pet's eye level. No standing up. Compare these to your usual top-down shots — see the difference?

⚡ CHALLENGE 2: BURST MODE PLAY

Play fetch or chase a toy. Hold burst mode the entire time. You should end up with 100+ photos. Find the ONE perfect mid-action frame.

🪟 CHALLENGE 3: WINDOW PORTRAIT

Position your pet near a window on an overcast day or in morning light. Take a portrait — focus on the eyes. Notice how soft and professional window light looks.

🔍 CHALLENGE 4: DETAILS ONLY

Don't photograph your whole pet. Shoot just their paws, nose, ears, or tail. These detail shots make beautiful Instagram carousels and tell a story differently.

🎨 CHALLENGE 5: ONE PET, ONE WEEK

Photograph the same pet every day for a week. Different times, different places. Notice how your photos improve and how you start seeing light differently.

📝 Your Photo Ideas & Notes

Shot ideas, locations to try, props to buy, editing experiments, favorite photos of your pet, Instagram hashtags to use, printing projects...

📸 The best photo of your pet hasn't been taken yet.
Go grab your phone!